

# **Phishing Awareness Analysis Report**

**DecodeLabs Cybersecurity Internship**  
**Week 3 Project**

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**Project Title**  
**Phishing Awareness Analysis**

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## **Table of Contents**

- 1. Introduction**
- 2. Objectives**
- 3. Sample Email 1 – Best Intern Award Scam**
- 4. Analysis of Sample Email 1**
- 5. Sample Email 2 – Fake Portal Verification**
- 6. Analysis of Sample Email 2**
- 7. General Recommendations**
- 8. Conclusion**

## **1. Introduction**

Phishing is one of the most common cyberattacks used by cybercriminals to trick people into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, bank details, or personal information. Attackers often pretend to be trusted organizations and use fake emails or messages to create urgency, excitement, or fear so that victims act without thinking carefully.

For this project, I analyzed two mock phishing emails created for educational purposes. The aim of the analysis is to identify phishing indicators, explain why the emails are suspicious, and suggest ways users can protect themselves from similar attacks.

## **2. Objectives**

The objectives of this project are to:

- Understand how phishing attacks work.
- Identify common phishing indicators in emails.
- Explain why phishing emails are dangerous.
- Improve phishing detection and security awareness skills.
- Recommend best practices for avoiding phishing attacks.

## **3. Sample Email 1 – Best Intern Award Scam**

The email below was created as a mock phishing email for educational purposes. It pretends to come from DecodeLabs and claims that an intern has won a ₦10,000,000 cash prize and a fully sponsored trip to Canada. The purpose of this email is to trick the recipient into revealing sensitive personal and financial information.

**From:** [awards@decode labs-support.com](mailto:awards@decode labs-support.com)

**To:** [miraclegodwin@example.com](mailto:miraclegodwin@example.com)

**Subject:** Congratulation! You Have Been Selected as DecodeLabs Best Intern – Claim Your ₦10,000,000 Prize & Canada Sponsorship

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Dear Intern,

Congratulation!

Following an outstanding review of your cybersecurity projects, you have been selected as the **Best DecodeLabs Cybersecurity Intern of the Year**. Your Password Strength Checker and Cryptography Tool was carefully reviewed by our international selection committee.

As part of this achievement, you have qualify to receive the following rewards:

- ₦10,000,000 Cash Prize
- Free Visa Processing to Canada
- Fully Sponsored Flight Ticket
- Employment Recommendation Letter
- Exclusive Cybersecurity Scholarship

To claim your rewards, you must complete your verification within **24 hours**. Failure to do so will result in your award been cancel and transfer to another intern.

Click the secure verification link below immediately:

<https://decode labs-awards.com/claim-reward>

During the verification, you will need to provide the following informations:

- Full Name
- Phone Number
- Home Address
- National ID Number
- Bank Account Details
- Debit Card Number
- CVV and Expiry Date (for identity verification)

Kindly do not reply this email because our mailbox are not monitored. Delay in verification may cause permanent lost of your reward.

Congratulation once again!

Best Regards,

**Awards Department**

DecodeLabs Internship Team

## **4. Analysis of Sample Email 1**

After reviewing the email, I identified several signs that indicate it is a phishing attempt.

### **4.1 Suspicious Sender Address**

The sender uses [awards@decodelabs-support.com](mailto:awards@decodelabs-support.com), which is different from what I would expect from an official DecodeLabs email address. Cybercriminals often create fake domains that look similar to legitimate organizations to gain the victim's trust.

### **4.2 Too-Good-to-Be-True Offer**

The email claims that the recipient has won a ₦10,000,000 cash prize, free visa processing, a sponsored flight ticket, and other rewards. Unexpected rewards like these are commonly used to attract victims and encourage them to act quickly.

### **4.3 Creates a Sense of Urgency**

The email states that the reward will be cancelled if verification is not completed within **24 hours**. Creating urgency is a common social engineering tactic because it pressures victims into making quick decisions without carefully checking the email.

### **4.4 Suspicious Link**

The email contains the following link:

<https://decodelabs-awards.com/claim-reward>

Although the link contains the name "DecodeLabs," the domain appears suspicious and should be verified before clicking. Users should always check links carefully instead of trusting them based only on their appearance.

#### **4.5 Requests Sensitive Information**

The email asks the recipient to provide personal and financial information, including:

- National ID Number
- Bank Account Details
- Debit Card Number
- CVV and Expiry Date

Legitimate organizations rarely request banking details or card information through email.

#### **4.6 Grammar and Spelling Errors**

Several grammar mistakes appear throughout the email, including:

- "Congratulation!" instead of "Congratulations!"
- "have qualify" instead of "have qualified"
- "award been cancel" instead of "award being cancelled"
- "informations" instead of "information"
- "mailbox are" instead of "mailbox is"
- "permanent lost" instead of "permanent loss"

While grammar mistakes alone do not always mean an email is malicious, they are common indicators found in many phishing emails.

#### **4.7 Risk Assessment**

**Risk Level:** High

This email contains multiple phishing indicators, including a fake sender address, unrealistic rewards, urgency, suspicious links, requests for sensitive information, and grammatical errors. Based on these findings, I would classify it as a high-risk phishing email and advise users not to click the link or provide any personal information.

## 5. Sample Email 2 – Fake DecodeLabs Portal Verification

The email below is another mock phishing email created for educational purposes. Unlike the first example, this email attempts to create fear by claiming that the recipient's DecodeLabs internship account is at risk of being suspended unless it is verified immediately. The goal is to trick the user into revealing their login credentials.

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**From:** [support@decodelabs-security.com](mailto:support@decodelabs-security.com)

**To:** [miraclegodwin@example.com](mailto:miraclegodwin@example.com)

**Subject:** Important: Verify Your DecodeLabs Internship Portal Account Immediately

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Dear DecodeLabs Intern,

Our security team have detected unusual activity on your internship portal account.

To keep your account active and avoid temporary suspension, you are require to verify your account within **12 hours**.

If your account is not verified before the deadline, you may lose access to:

- Internship Dashboard
- Weekly Assignments
- Project Submissions
- Internship Certificate
- Mentor Feedback

Please click the secure verification link below to confirm your account information:

<https://decodelabs-portal-verify.com/login>

After clicking the link, you will be ask to confirm the following details:

- Full Name
- Registered Email Address
- Internship ID
- Password
- One-Time Verification Code (OTP)

Failure to verify your account immediately may result in permanent account suspension.

Please do not ignore this important notification.

Thank you for your co-operation.

Best Regards,

**DecodeLabs Security Team**

Internship Support Department

## 6. Analysis of Sample Email 2

After reviewing this email, I identified several indicators that suggest it is a phishing attempt.

### 6.1 Suspicious Sender Address

The sender uses [support@decodelabs-security.com](mailto:support@decodelabs-security.com) instead of an official DecodeLabs email address. Attackers often register similar-looking domains to make fake emails appear trustworthy.

### 6.2 Fear and Urgency

The email claims that the recipient's account will be suspended within **12 hours** if verification is not completed. Creating fear and urgency is a common phishing technique because it encourages users to react quickly without verifying the message.

### 6.3 Suspicious Verification Link

The email provides the following link:

<https://decodelabs-portal-verify.com/login>

Although the link contains the name "DecodeLabs," it is not confirmed to be an official DecodeLabs website. Users should always verify website addresses before entering their login details.

### 6.4 Requests Login Credentials

The email asks the recipient to provide:

- Internship ID
- Password
- One-Time Verification Code (OTP)



Legitimate organizations rarely ask users to submit their passwords or OTPs through links sent in emails. This is a major warning sign of credential theft.

### **6.5 Grammar Errors**

The email contains several grammar mistakes, including:

- "team have detected" instead of "team has detected"
- "you are require" instead of "you are required"
- "will be ask" instead of "will be asked"

These mistakes reduce the credibility of the email and are common in many phishing attempts.

### **6.6 Risk Assessment**

**Risk Level:** High

This email contains multiple phishing indicators, including a fake sender address, a suspicious verification link, urgency, requests for login credentials, and grammar mistakes. I would classify this email as a high-risk phishing attempt and recommend that users avoid clicking the link or providing any account credentials.

## **7. General Recommendations**

Based on the analysis of both phishing emails, I recommend the following security practices to help users avoid becoming victims of phishing attacks:

- Always verify the sender's email address before responding to any message.
- Avoid clicking on links from unexpected or suspicious emails.
- Check website URLs carefully before entering login credentials or personal information.
- Be cautious of emails that create urgency or promise unrealistic rewards.
- Never share passwords, One-Time Passwords (OTPs), bank details, or debit card information through email.

- Watch out for grammar mistakes, spelling errors, and unusual formatting in emails.
- If you are unsure whether an email is legitimate, contact the organization directly using its official website or support channels instead of replying to the email.
- Regular cybersecurity awareness training can help users recognize phishing attempts and reduce the risk of falling victim to social engineering attacks.

## **8. Conclusion**

This project helped me better understand how phishing attacks use social engineering techniques such as urgency, fake rewards, fear, and impersonation to trick users into revealing sensitive information.

By analyzing the two mock phishing emails, I learned how to identify common phishing indicators, including suspicious sender addresses, fake links, requests for sensitive information, grammatical mistakes, and unrealistic claims.

Overall, this project improved my phishing awareness skills and reinforced the importance of carefully examining emails before clicking links, downloading attachments, or sharing personal information. These are important skills for anyone working in cybersecurity and for everyday internet users.

## **Disclaimer**

The phishing emails included in this report are fictional examples created by the author for educational purposes as part of the DecodeLabs Cybersecurity Internship. They are intended solely to demonstrate common phishing techniques and support cybersecurity awareness training. They do not represent actual communications from DecodeLabs or any other organization.